A CEO's Stealing Thunder on Twitter

Analysis of the Effects of a CEO's Proactive Self-Disclosure of Crisis Information Via Twitter*

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As crisis management in social media cycles with real-time communication, a CEO's Twitter is considered to be a well-fitted crisis communication channel to effectively respond to any crisis. This study investigates the effects of a CEO's stealing thunder via Twitter – a proactive tweeting strategy for self-disclosing crisis information. Results from experimental data suggest that the incident of a CEO's stealing thunder during a crisis, as opposed to situations of the non-tweeting, the organization's tweeting, and a news media's tweeting on the crisis, had higher levels of credibility and lower levels of negative word-of-mouth ratings in regards to the organizational crisis response. The results show that proactive self-disclosure of crisis information through a CEO's Twitter could be an effective strategy for crisis management to cope within the one-click social media environment.

Key words: Twitter, social media, CEO, stealing thunder, crisis management

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1. Introduction

In the age of social media, potentially all publics are the media(Gillmor, 2006). Due to viral attacks from diverse media publics and the social characteristics of new media, organizations tend to face risks more frequently than ever(Liu, 2010; Sweetser & Metzgar, 2007). The interactivity of online media users and high speed of information connectivity mean that crisis communication messages spread more quickly to a variety of destinations(Liu, Austin, & Jin, 2011). In order to manage crises in a highly interactive social media space, organizations must be well-prepared to respond quickly and flexibly. This calls for organizational readiness to act in the social media environment in the event of a crisis. The literature also emphasizes that timely crisis response via social media is increasingly important. Thus, the strategic selection of where and when to communicate, as well as the role of the messenger in social media, are essential for crisis communication. In other words, social media challenges traditional communication practices that have mainly focused on the issue of what or how to communicate, such as the art of writing a press release during an organizational crisis.

Regarding the issue of where, many recent scholars have considered Twitter as more effective as a crisis communication medium than any other organizational media(Evans, Twomey, & Talan, 2011; Gilpin, 2010; Park & Jeong, 2011; Schultz, Utz, & Göritz, 2011). For instance, Schultz and his colleagues'(2011) analysis of experimental data has demonstrated the effect of Twitter as a medium in crisis management. They claimed that "crisis communication via Twitter led to less negative crisis reactions than blogs and newspaper articles" and "the medium matters more than the message"(p. 25). Park and Jeong(2011) also insisted that Twitter plays a leading role in guiding people to communicate online across diverse social media platforms. Likewise, after conducting semantic network analyses on public relations channels, Gilpin(2010) pointed out that Twitter is "the most intrinsically dialogic medium" comparing with blogs and online news releases(p. 279). These previous studies suggest that

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Twitter is a low-cost value-added platform for an organization's crisis management.

As for the issues of who and when to say it, however, very little research has been carried out regarding the application of Twitter. Even though the quick reactions of chief executive officers(CEOs) via Twitter during a crisis are emphasized anecdotally(Castaldo, 2010; Parpis, 2009; Salzberg, 2009), researchers have rarely empirically examined these actors' roles in crisis communications until now. Meanwhile, several studies recently have argued that proactive engagement creates opportunities to produce positive public relations outcomes(Bortreea & Seltzer, 2009; Kelleher, 2009). In addition, scholars cumulatively have demonstrated the effectiveness of the proactive self-disclosure strategy–called "stealing thunder"–for crisis management initiatives(Arpan & Pompper, 2003; Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005; Wigley, 2011). Despite these arguments, there is little research examining the effects of a CEO's proactive tweeting with respect to crisis communication.

By reviewing the critical roles of CEOs during crises, this study attempts to investigate the issues of who and when in Twitter communication. Specifically, using an experimental design, the researchers aim to examine whether a CEO's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information in Twitter activity during a crisis enhances perceptions of credibility for an organizational crisis response, resulting in acceptance of the response, and ultimately leading to less negative word-of-mouth about the crisis.

2. Literature review

1) CEO on Twitter as a crisis manager in chief

In the social media space, publics are now better connected; consumers feel as if they are engaged in a direct conversation with organizations(Kelleher, 2009; Liu, et al., 2011; Postman, 2009). Therefore, they

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expect to interact directly with the responsible parties in crises(Salzberg, 2009). Without this role, social media users are less tolerant of uncertainty and eager to listen to comments directly from the representatives of organizations. This implies that CEOs face an unprecedented challenge to be flexible enough to react promptly via social media to key publics(Rand & Rodriguez, 2007).

Although public relations aims to craft an organizational presence online and to enhance the public personae of their organizations in social media space, as an embedded part of organizational operations, the delegated communication made by public relations practitioners renders a necessary corollary to broadcasting non-humanized and unidirectional marketing(Crawford, 2009; Wilson, 2009). For example, Crawford(2009) argues that in the Twitter space, organizations that are able to hear the public's views and rapidly respond to public concerns might be reciprocal and can maintain a sense of unity, as opposed to organizations participating in "delegated listening"(p. 530). Wilson(2009) also contends that politicians on Twitter, instead of a pretending to be present, actively respond to dialogic social media users without the assistance of their communications staffs. Wilson argues that delegated tweeting by public relations staffs(i.e. "delegated listening") limits the delivery of humanized organizational voices and realistic reactions during crises.

However, interestingly, Smith(2010) maintains that any Twitter user representing an organization can play a crisis management role similar to that of a public relations manager. This means that traditional public relations functions are distributing socially, rather than officially fixed or designated, to recognized media operators. Anyone who has organizational legitimacy, meaning a sensible and morally justifiable actor in a given social media sphere, can serve as a public relations representative in the "public battlefield of meanings," a term designated by Ihlen and Van Ruler(2007) to describe the media environment. In this line of discussion, naturally a question arises: In a crisis developing in the social media space, who is the most appropriate person in an organization to respond?

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Addressing this question, an emerging argument presents the idea that CEOs must use Twitter at the forefront of crisis management(Castaldo, 2010; Schultz, et al., 2011). Several researchers have recently suggested that, somewhat similar to CEO capital, social media influencers[1] also have persuasive power (Freberga, Grahamb, McGaugheyc, & Freberg, 2011). CEOs are potentially the ideal candidates to fill social media influencer roles in their use of social media. In other words, by using their inherent stature and social capital, CEOs who use Twitter can be easily transformed into the influencers. Because the capital of a CEO in an organization contributes an organization's fundamental assets(Gaines-Ross, 2003), a CEO's Twitter is an effective public relations channel to communicate strategically for the organization(Gilpin, 2010). Moreover, the CEO on Twitter could be the most explicitly legitimized actor during a crisis because a CEO's tweeting creates more visible personae in crisis(Castaldo, 2010).

Due to these structural and social attributes of a CEO's Twitter account, CEOs on Twitter are arguably the best crisis communication managers. Thus, from a public relations standpoint, CEOs as organization spokespersons on Twitter must actively engage with social media users and be willing to understand the organizational legitimacy or capital for managing organizational crises in a public platform. These attributes also make Twitter use for public relations purposes increasingly inviting.

Traditionally, CEOs have shared the contingent nature of organizational communications in times of crisis. CEOs in the private and public sector have been involved with corporate communications because of the intrinsic need for organizations' survival(Arnold, 1988, 1989; Kim & Kim, 2007). In order to get media attention or to show the most distinctive voice of the organization, sometimes CEOs, as the organizational brains, are indirectly engaged with public relations activities by orchestrating the final stage of the decision-making process. In other cases, they partake

1) Social media influencers are defined as "a new type of independent third party endorsers who shape audience attitudes through blogs, tweets, and the use of other social media" (Freberga, Grahamb, McGaugheyc, & Freberg, 2011, p. 90).

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in more direct engagement with the public relations process by hosting media conferences or telling their stories to the public themselves(Gaines-Ross, 2003). However, the roles of CEOs have recently grown even more with the expansion of social media. While few CEOs want to go public with their Twitter accounts(Shandwick, 2010), publics look to the accounts more in a crisis because they personify an organization; publics also perceive the CEO's Twitter as equivalent to the organizational representation(Castaldo, 2010; Crawford, 2009; Gilpin, 2010).

Increasingly, CEOs need to engage with publics using their Twitter accounts during crises. There is a demand for conducting scientific study on how CEOs inhabit the Twitter space, even though it presents a challenge to organizational leadership. Previous research detects a causal link between adoption of social media and public relations power in communications(Curtis et al., 2010; Diga & Kelleher, 2009; Porter, Trammell, Chungc, & Kim, 2007). Moreover, scholars have argued that public relations must engage in social media use since the social media space is an ideal environment to interact with publics(Bortreea & Seltzer, 2009; Bruning, Dials, & Shirka, 2008), and because organizations that utilize social media platforms are able to deliver their conversational human voices to key public venues during crises(Kelleher, 2009; Kelleher & Miller, 2006; Liu, 2010). Even though there are few studies that address the response strategy of CEOs during crises, based on previous literature reviews, it could be posited that a CEO's tweeting for crisis management leads to a more positive perception of organizational crisis response than the organizational tweeting operated by public relations staff. Non-tweeting from the organization could also be a less desirable choice than a CEO's tweeting during a crisis.

2) Effects of CEOs' proactive self-disclosure of crisis information via Twitter

Despite a lack of academic public relations research on Twitter, some consensus exists regarding the usefulness of the Twitter medium in crisis

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management(Schultz, et al., 2011; Xifra & Grau, 2010). Of course, some may dispute that 140-character or fewer tweets constitute true crisis communication, however, Gilpin(2010) contends that conversely, a tweet can be a quick construction of a condensed and meaningful message that can guide the public to important main organizational webpages. Gilpin(2010) also highlighted that Twitter is the most effective tool, arguing that there are multiple social media tools which can be used as organizational communication channels. It expands online public relations activities by guiding the public to information resources and announces the publication of organizational social media. In turn, this activity induces traffic to organizational websites such as corporate blog posts and news release pages. Accordingly, Twitter potentially gives organizations initiative to broadcast timely crisis messages and to cope with stakeholders' concerns.

Regarding organizational initiative in conflict resolution situations, the effectiveness of stealing thunder as a proactive self-disclosure strategy has been proven not only in the application of legal communication, but also in crisis communication. By definition, stealing thunder is "revealing negative information about oneself before it is revealed or elicited by another person"(Williams, Bourgeois, & Croyle, 1993, p. 597). Even though some legal scholars have addressed that stealing thunder as a courtroom tactic may be ineffective because it makes jurors suspicious of the person who had used the tactic(Klonoff & Colby, 1990), or because it encourages awareness of the self-discloser's use of persuasion(Dolnik, Case, & Williams, 2003), commonly crisis scholars have regarded it as a useful strategy in crisis management. For example, when an organization steals thunder during crises, the organization receives less negative news coverage from the media(Wigley, 2011). Also, the organization's public relations practitioners are perceived as more credible than journalists(Arpan & Pompper, 2003). Even consumers have higher levels of purchasing intention for any of the organization's products involved in a crisis when the organization steals thunder(Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005).

However, although the proactive reactions of CEOs to crises are sup-

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ported anecdotally in the viral conditions of the Twitter age(Castaldo, 2010; Parpis, 2009; Salzberg, 2009), there is little discussion about the effects of CEOs' stealing thunder strategies via Twitter in crisis communication. Castaldo(2010) claims that the CEO on Twitter is the best person to be developed quickly as a human face for an organization and to cultivate organization-public relationships within the social media space. Likewise, Salzberg(2009) adds that CEOs should respond to challenges promptly by "standing flat-footed in a room, listening and offering, as best he or she can, the plain, unvarnished truth" because, via Twitter, crisis news can spread out faster than ever. Organizations that fail to act in a timely manner in public-led conversations see that their public's perceptions of the organizations' responsibilities decay more quickly(Smits & Ally, 2003), even in the social media space. Therefore, in order to deliver the right message over the right time in a crisis, it is argued that CEOs on Twitter need to be part of proactive crisis communication strategies. Previous arguments have suggested that CEOs should act in a timely fashion to manage crisis situations. Given the importance of the CEOs' proactive tweeting in crisis communication, the CEOs in a crisis could be strategically developed by using the stealing thunder strategy.

In developing CEOs' tweeting strategies in crises, timeliness or proactive self-disclosure of crisis information via Twitter might be considered, as Twitter has been used as the most proactive communication channel in the one-click media environment. As noted previously, Twitter has the capacity to lead stakeholders to be aware of organizational information sources, despite the constantly striving traditional media; it also has a precedent of being timelier than other media platforms and can construct situational frames for the management of crises(Gilpin, 2010). Like a tour guide, a CEO's timely tweeting in crisis can expand further and open up a new space for organizations to initiate crisis management by defining meanings of a crisis situation. However, if organizations fail use Twitter as a tool for crisis management, Twitter may be transformed into a risky venue for organizations. As Twitter provides an organization in crisis with an opportunity to interact quickly with key audiences, the "stealing thun-

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der" strategy could be an ideal option for CEOs to utilize in crisis communication.

Even though previous attempts to examine the effects of CEOs' proactive tweeting strategies during a crisis have been fragmentary at best, previous research has predicted that both CEOs in crisis communication roles and their fast responses—the stealing thunder strategy—may contribute to crisis management in social media situations. Crisis scholars arguing for timeliness in crisis management initiatives have examined the effectiveness of the proactive self-disclosure strategy(Arpan & Pompper, 2003; Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005; Wigley, 2011). Others have insisted that the issue of CEOs' quickest responses in social media should be more emphasized in crisis communication(Collingwood, 2009; Parpis, 2009). Therefore, it could be hypothesized that a CEO's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information via Twitter receives a more favorable assessment of organizational crisis response, greater likelihood to accept the account for the organizational response, and less likelihood to join in negative word-of-mouth behavior than when a news media's Twitter(which operated by journalists) tweets, the organization's Twitter(which operated by public relations staff) tweets, and even when no one tweets on the crisis. Based on these arguments, following hypotheses are proposed:

H1: When a CEO voluntarily tweets to disclose the crisis information of his or her organization, the participants are more likely to rate the organizational crisis response as credible than when no one voluntary tweets (H1a), the organization's Twitter tweets (H1b), or a news media's Twitter tweets (H1c) about the crisis situation.

H2: When a CEO voluntarily tweets to disclose the crisis information of his or her organization, the participants are more likely to rate the organizational crisis response as understandable than when no one voluntary tweets(H2a), the organization's Twitter tweets (H2b), or a news media's Twitter tweets (H2c) about the crisis situation.

H3: When a CEO voluntarily tweets to disclose the crisis information of his or her organization, the participants are less likely to spread negative

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word-of-mouth communication than when no one voluntary tweets(H3a), the organizational Twitter tweets(H3b), or a news media's Twitter tweets(H3c) about the crisis situation.

3. Method

1) Design and Stimuli

The experiment employed a between-subjects design with four different stimulus conditions: CEO's tweeting, organization's tweeting, news media's tweeting, and non-tweeting. In order to manipulate a crisis situation in the experimental setting, this study used a fictitious corporation. This fictitious organization contributes to avoid potential confounding effects of pre-existing organizational reputation. Each Twitter message included information about a toxic dye being used by a clothing company that may have caused young student consumers to contract an extremely virulent skin disease. Stealing thunder and thunder conditions were manipulated by changing sources of the revelation(Twitter operators) about the crisis. For example, in the CEO Twitter's stealing thunder condition, the message indicated that a CEO revealed the crisis information and notified that his organization would express official responses in a press conference regarding the crisis. With the exception of a control condition in which Twitter messages were not exposed to participants, the Twitter messages in three conditions were identical except for the operators of the Twitter accounts who disclosed the crisis information about the organization and its scheduled press release.[2] To examine the effects of a CEO's self-disclosure via Twitter, no full level of accommodation was ma-

2) Three Twitter accounts as stimuli have identical profiles (i.e., follower and following numbers) except names and main images on the Twitters. In the CEO Twitter setting, the photo of a male wearing a suit and tie who aged about 50 was shown; in the organizational Twitter setting, the company's logo was shown; in the media Twitter setting, a major broadcasting news media' logo was presented.

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nipulated on the information in a press release, by making the corporate responsibility for the crisis ambiguous, and by having the corporate withhold the expression of official apology. The Twitter message was first unveiled by a CEO in the CEO's stealing-thunder condition; it was first uncovered by public relations staff in the organizational stealing-thunder condition; it was first revealed by a news medium in the thunder condition. The crisis scenario and three mock Twitter messages were reviewed by a working journalist and by a dermatologist for medical validity.

2) Participants and Procedure

This study had a two-phase design: Phase I—the inducement of perceptions of a crisis(severity and responsibility), Phase II—the manipulation of Twitter messages and measurement of the organization's official press release(credibility, acceptance, and negative word-of-mouth).

In the first phase, in order to simulate a crisis situation, all of the participants were asked to read the stimulus materials on the experimental websites which described the crisis situation with three provocative pictures showing a serious skin disease appearing on young female students' legs due to the poisonous clothing of the organization. Then, participants were asked to complete a brief questionnaire which would be used as a control variable.

In the second phase, three Twitter messages were constructed on websites, which were almost the same as the Twitter.com setting. Being asked to read the next message carefully, participants were randomly selected to receive only one of four Twitter messages including the non-tweeting group. Then, participants were told that the corporate's official response was released on the following day after the first breaking Twitter message(in the control group, it was written as "day after the first breaking the situation") and were asked to read the corporate's press release in which the corporation explained the current crisis situation,

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contended the relationship between the imported fabric from China and the crisis, expressed concerns for the victims, and suggested preventive measures. After reading the released article, participants were asked to answer in second questionnaire designed to measure dependent variables.

Participants in this experiment were active Twitter users who used their Twitter at least once a week and enrolled in introductory communication courses at a major online university in South Korea. Their ages ranged from 18 to 56(M=32, SD=1.55). Participants were 49.1% female(n=108) and 50.9% male(n=112). Each treatment condition had 55 participants. Participants received extra credit.

3) Measures

Credibility of the organizational response was operationalized as the degree to which the organizational press release was perceived as honest, trustworthy, and sincere. It was measured by three items on a five-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1(strongly disagree) to 5(strongly agree). The index(M=3.03, SD=.93) was reliable(α=.91).

Coombs and Holladay(2008) defined account acceptance as "how respondents feel about the crisis response offered by the organization"(p. 253). Also Blumstein and his colleagues(1974) measured account acceptance with favorability and acceptability. Following previous studies, account acceptance was measured by three items; each item captures emotional acceptability on a five-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1(strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree): favorably, acceptingly, and pleasantly. The index(M=3.12, SD=.87) was reliable(α=.94).

Negative word-of-mouth intention was defined as participants' future behavioral intentions regarding the crisis toward the company, which was measured by three items on a five-point Likert-type scale based on the scale adopted by Coombs and Holladay(2008): I would not encourage my friends or relatives to buy products from the company. If I have the

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opportunity in the future, I would say negative things about the company and its products to others. Also, when someone asks for my advice, I would not recommend the company's products. The index(M=2.57, SD=.90) reversed was also reliable(α=.89).

In addition, perceived organizational responsibility for the crisis was also measured as a potential control variable. Based on the Situational Crisis Communication Theory(SCCT)(Coombs & Holladay, 2002), responsibility impacts the participants' assessments for the organizational response. In order to control perceived organizational responsibility prompted by a given crisis, two items were used adapted from J. Kim, H. J. Kim, and Cameron(2009): "I think the organization should be bear responsibility for the crisis," and "I think the organization should be blamed for the crisis." The response scale ranged from 1(strongly disagree) to 5(strongly agree). The index(M=4.01, SD=.64) was reliable(α=.94).

4. Results

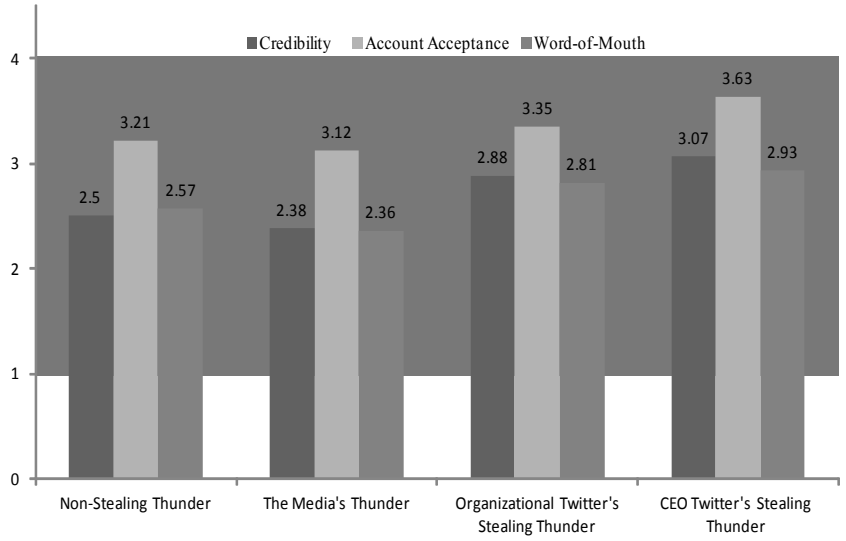
All hypotheses were tested using a series of ANCOVAs with the participants' perceptions of an organization's crisis responsibility as the covariate and credibility perceptions, account acceptance, and word-of-mouth as dependent variables. Regarding the credibility variable, the first hypotheses(〈H1a〉, 〈H2a〉, and 〈H3a〉) predicted that when a CEO voluntarily tweets to disclose crisis information(CEO Twitter's stealing thunder), the participants are more likely to rate the organizational crisis responses as credible, as opposed to when participants cannot find voluntary tweets(non-stealing thunder), public relations staff tweets(organizational Twitter's stealing thunder), and news media tweets(thunder condition).

In order to test first hypotheses(〈H1a〉, 〈H1b〉, and 〈H1c〉), a series of ANCOVAs were conducted on participants' perceptions of credibility toward the corporate message. When controlling their perceived organizational responsibility for the crisis, an ANCOVA revealed that there was a significant difference between the crisis information disclosures. As

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shown in Figure 1, in response to information released in advance by the CEO's tweeting, participants reported the corporate response as more credible(CEO Twitter's stealing thunder; M=3.07, SD=1.50) than in the non-stealing condition(M=2.50, SD=.87), supporting H1a(F[1,110]=10.54, p=.002, par. η^2=.087); and the thunder condition(M=2.38, SD=.90), supporting H1c(F[1,104]=11.05, p<.001, par. η^2=.096). However, there were no statistically significant differences between the CEO and the organizational Twitters' stealing thunde (M=2.88, SD=.88) condition, not supporting H1b(F[1,111]=.621, p=.432, par. η^2=.006).

For the account acceptance variable, the second hypotheses(〈H2a〉, 〈H2b〉, and 〈H2c〉) predicted that those in the CEO Twitter's stealing thunder group are more likely to accept the organizational crisis response than those in the non-stealing thunder, organizational Twitter's stealing thunder, and the thunder groups. While controlling the perceived organizational responsibility, a series of ANCOVAs' results confirmed that those exposed to a CEO Twitter's stealing thunder are more likely to accept the corporate message group(M=3.63, SD=.81) than those in the



〈Figure 1〉 Comparison of average group ratings for each dependent variable

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non-stealing condition(M=3.21, SD=.65), supporting 〈H2a〉(F[1,110]=8.83, p=.003, par. η^2=.075); than those in the organizational Twitter's stealing thunder condition(M=3.35, SD=.64), supporting 〈H2b〉(F[1,111]=11.05, p=.029, par. η^2=.042); and than those in the thunder condition(M=3.12, SD=.87), supporting H2c(F[1,104]=10.35, p=.002, par. η^2=.091).

As for the word-of-mouth variable, the third hypotheses(〈H3a〉, 〈H3b〉, and 〈H3c〉) predicted that those in the CEO Twitter's stealing thunder group were less likely to spread negative word-of-mouth about the crisis as opposed to those who were in the non-stealing thunder, organizational Twitter's stealing thunder, and the thunder conditions. Consistent with the previous ANCOVAs, results indicated that those in the CEO Twitter's stealing thunder condition were less likely to spread the crisis(M=2.93, SD=1.10) compared with those in the non-stealing condition(M=2.57, SD=1.00), partially supporting 〈H3a〉(F[1,110]=3.38, p=.069, par. η^2=.030) although the difference felt short of the $p < .05$ significance level; this was also true in comparison with the thunder condition(M=2.36, SD=.80), supporting H3c(F[1,104]=8.30, p=.005, par. η^2=.074). Contrary to these findings, there was not any statistically significant difference between the CEO Twitter' stealing and the organizational Twitter' stealing thunder(M=2.81, SD=.99), not supporting 〈H3b〉(F[1,111]=2.82, p=.597, par. η^2=.003).

Additionally, in consideration of exploring the effects of general stealing thunder in crisis communication, this study examined whether there were any differences between organizational stealing and the news media's thunder situations. Controlling for the perceived responsibility variable again, results revealed that those in the organizational stealing thunder situation yielded higher levels of credibility for the press release(F[1,104]=8.12, p=.005, par. η^2=.072) and lower level of negative word-of-mouth related with the crisis(F[1,104]=5.36, p=.012, par. η^2=.059) than those in the media's thunder situation, echoing with the previous studies on stealing thunder(Arpan & Pompper, 2003; Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005), but there was no statistically significant difference in levels of ac-

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count acceptance(F[1,104]=2.66, p=.105, par. η^2=.025).

5. Discussion

Recent crisis scholars have revealed that the organization's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information affects the public's responses to a given corporate crisis(Arpan & Pompper, 2003; Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005; Wigley, 2011). Also, Twitter has unique medium effects as a social media platform that leads individuals to be more attentive of organizational crisis communications(Evans, et al., 2011; Schultz, et al., 2011). Similarly, a CEO's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information via Twitter affects how individuals perceive officially issued messages by the responsible company. This study was designed to examine the effects of the CEO's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information using Twitter－stealing thunder－on public responses toward the crisis message.

In comparing with the CEO Twitter's stealing thunder, the organizational Twitter's stealing thunder, a news media's thunder, and non-stealing thunder(as a control group) situations, experimental results indicated that a CEO's stealing thunder might result in more enhanced credibility, account acceptance, and less negative word-of-mouth ratings for the organizational official response. These results indicate that the CEO's active engagement with the public via social media is an important quality of crisis communication.

In particular, comparing with the non-tweeting situation, the CEO's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information via Twitter was more effective in predicting positive outcomes. Despite the fact that, to date, the majority of CEOs are reluctant to operate via Twitter(Shandwick, 2010), this result suggests that a CEO's presence on Twitter and proactive disclosure of crisis information could constitute an appropriate crisis management strategy in the social media context. From a public relations standpoint, this finding also yields some concrete support for the argument that CEOs might engage with publics via social media to manage potential

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crises and to build and maintain relationships with the public.

In the context of this stealing thunder study, the effects of proactive self-disclosure of crisis information by a CEO and public relations practitioners show the potential synergistic effects because of the two actors' roles in enhancing credibility ratings for the response of the responsible company, and in reducing negative word-of-mouth regarding the crisis. This may be due to the general effects of stealing thunder. Regardless of act of who (i.e., CEOs or public relations practitioners), the findings suggest if any actor belonging to an organization unveils faster crisis information than any third party(i.e., news media), the public is more likely to perceive the organizational message as more credible and to have less potential negative word-of-mouth communication. These results reinforce previous research that found an organization is perceived as more credible and receives less negative news coverage from the media when an organization steals thunder during a crisis(Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005; Wigley, 2011). This aligns with the argument that organizations must be highly involved in proactive crisis communication via social media(Evans, et al., 2011; Porter, et al., 2007; Sweetser & Metzgar, 2007).

However, in accounting for acceptance of organizational response, which was measured with the emotional acceptability produced by Twitter messages, the CEO's proactive self-disclosure situation carried more significant advantage in escalating the likelihood of acceptance than public relations practitioners' tweeting. Although it appears that both CEOs' and public relations practitioners' Twitter accounts have the ability to effectively communicate crisis messages by stealing thunder, this finding shows the CEO's tweeting may be particularly well suited for conveying an "emotional touch" or "human voice" in the social media context. As a humanized character, the CEO's tweeting and stealing thunder may render the public to recognize a conversational humanized voice of the organization; this potential phenomenon may be a reason that the CEO's stealing thunder effects have more power than public relations practitioners' stealing thunder. By nature, the CEO's stealing thunder has more emotional appeal because it may elicit the presence of the CEO via Twitter and

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improve perceptions of organizational involvement; this emotional appeal can trigger organizational response acceptance. As stated earlier in this article, this result is corroborating with previous arguments. Delivering a conversational human voice via social media induces the public to feel that the organization will do better in establishing, maintaining relationships, and even managing crises(Kelleher, 2009; Sweetser & Metzgar, 2007). Thus the CEO's usual, active, and proactive tweeting may serve as valuable tools in an organization's array of social media-mediated crisis communication strategies.

Interestingly, the effects of a CEO's stealing thunder become particularly obvious, even after the perceived organizational responsibility for the crisis is controlled. This suggests that the public within the CEO's stealing thunder group may have held different views about the organizational response. Previous communication research has mainly argued that organizations' decisions on which accommodative strategies to deploy depend on the perceived organizational crisis responsibility(Coombs & Holladay, 2007, 2008). Nonetheless, the causality between CEOs' proactive self-disclosure of crisis information and crisis management results are beyond the predictive power of the perceived organizational responsibility toward the crisis. This comparison illustrates the importance of integrated access to understanding the issues of when, where, and who when responding to crises in the social media space(as well as the issue of what the public perceives in the crisis, dominantly addressed in previous research). In other words, the findings provide good opportunities to continue exploring areas of overlap between the social distributions of public relations roles(Smith, 2010), relational maintenance strategies(i.e., conversational human voice)(Kelleher, 2009), and crisis management strategies(i.e., selections of social medium)(Liu, et al., 2011; Schultz, et al., 2011; Sweetser & Metzgar, 2007).

Overall, this study suggests some theoretical and practical implications for crisis management, specifically, the strategy of stealing thunder via the CEO's Twitter. Clearly, stealing thunder can influence public perceptions of organizational response and behavioral intentions to dis-

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seminate the crisis message beyond the perceived organizational crisis responsibility. The observed effects of the CEO's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information echoes what previous crisis studies are pointing to: Twitter is a good platform to shepherd publics to be attentive to organizational crisis responses and the operators of the Twitter accounts should be chiefly representative for responsible organizations. Moreover, important insights from our findings suggest that depending on the actors, particularly the CEOs who are representing the organizations and engaging with publics as conversational human voices via social media, may play a crucial role in managing crises. Consequently, this study extends Arpan and Roskos-Ewoldsen's(2005) findings by demonstrating that stealing thunder induces credibility and reduces intentions to partake in negative word-of-mouth communication, and by suggesting that CEOs must be an important part of the crisis communication process, exerting their potential capital in the social media space.

However, it is noteworthy that this study probed how stealing thunder from a CEO or a public relations actor can be instrumental to an organization's proactive self-disclosure of crisis information. These results hardly find difference in credibility for the response and likelihood of negative word-of-mouth. In other words, there is little or no difference between CEO and PR practitioner stealing thunder sources in terms of credibility and the likelihood that publics will engage in negative word-of-mouth behavior. The results that the CEO's stealing thunder has effects only in account acceptance still show an important place for crisis scholars to investigate the roles of actors in crisis management via social media. For example, there might be differences in crisis management effects of stealing thunder among CEOs, public relations practitioners, and so-called 'A-list' bloggers, or 'power-Twitter operators' who belong to an organization. In addition, corporate webpages are still as important as social media.

Since organizations' online information sources(i.e. webpages and directories) remain the important "first line" sources for the media(Lariscy, Averyb, Sweetser, & Howes, 2009, p. 316), future research has to examine

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how organizational social media and organizational websites integrate to maximize opportunity for crisis management. In an attempt to deliver corporate responses to a given crisis situation, practitioners may be able to utilize organizational communication platforms(corporate websites, major blogs, and online press releases) and social media for directly communicating with key publics.

This study used a fictitious organization to control existing organization-public relationships; however, online relationships sustained or cultivated by an organization's social media activities may influence public perceptions of crisis information in a real situation or case. Thus, additional experiments involving real organizations and diverse kinds of crises are needed in future research. Also, the results and analyses of this research are solely based on a sample of university students and are thus limited. In order to reassess or elaborate on these research findings, further studies should be designed to replicate these findings.

Lastly, although this research used a simple Twitter message to disclose the crisis information and to notify the press, crisis researchers(e.g., Coombs, 2007) have argued that certain message frames could lead to more favorable responses from publics(Coombs & Holladay, 2007; Kim, et al., 2009; Schultz, et al., 2011; Wigley, 2011). Future research should investigate more Twitter message factors, which could possibly affect the public's emotional response, credibility evaluations, and even intentional behaviors regarding a given organizational crisis. There is a place for this type of research in the future as Waters, Tindall, and Morton(2010) argued, "proper public relations must be proactive and engaged in monitoring the organization's surroundings" even on "the virtual environment(p. 260)". It follows that public relations experts should continue to seek out new social media strategies and communication actors for developing relationships with key target publics online.

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국문초록

조직체 최고경영자 트위터를 통한 선제적 위기정보 공개전략 연구

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소셜미디어 시대의 실시간적인 커뮤니케이션 환경은 조직체의 최고경영자(CEO)가 직접 다양한 소셜 미디어 채널을 통해 신속하고 효과적으로 위기관리에 참여해야만 하는 당위성을 부여하고 있다. 이러한 맥락에서 본 연구는 CEO의 트위터(Twitter)를 통한 적극적이고 사전대응적인 위기관리 참여의 효과를 탐색해 보고자 하였다. 구체적으로 CEO가 자신의 트위터를 통해 조직체 위기 정보를 신속하게 선제적으로 공개하는 전략(stealing thunder strategy)이 언론에 의한 위기상황 공개(thundering), 조직체 PR 부서에 의한 선제적 공개(organizational stealing thunder), 그리고 사전 위기정보 공개가 없는 상황을 고려했을 때 어떠한 위기관리 효과를 나타내는지를 실증적으로 비교분석하고자 하였다. 이를 위한 실험연구결과(N=220), 위기상황에 대한 CEO의 선제적 공개전략은 언론에 의한 위기상황 보도나 조직체 PR부서의 선제적 공개전략보다 긍정적인 위기관리 메시지 신뢰도와 수용성을 보였고, 부정적인 입소문(word-of-mouth) 행위의도를 감화시키는 효과를 나타냈다. 본 연구결과는 빠른 호흡의 디지털 소통환경에서 CEO의 소셜미디어를 통한 선제적인 위기정보 노출이 유용한 위기관리 전략으로 활용될 수 있음을 실증적으로 제시했다는 데 의의를 찾을 수 있다.

주제어: 트위터, 소셜미디어, CEO, 선제적 위기정보 공개, 위기관리

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